

WeSay tutorial

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What is WeSay?

WeSay is a lightweight, user-friendly application developed by SIL International for building dictionaries and lexical databases. It is especially designed for:

- Community language projects
- Under-documented languages
- Field linguistics and language documentation

Unlike more complex tools (like FieldWorks Language Explorer (FLEX)), WeSay is simple, fast, and collaborative.

What you can do with WeSay

- Add words
- Record pronunciations
- Write definitions and examples
- Work collaboratively with a team
- Sync data between users

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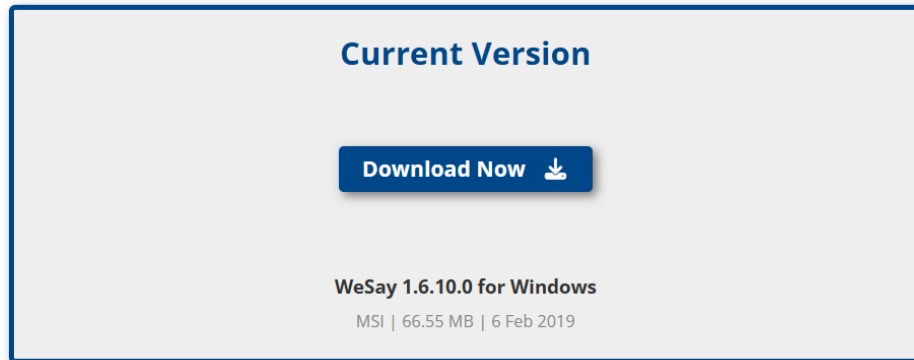
Step-by-Step: How to use WeSay

Step 1: Install WeSay

- Download WeSay from the SIL website

[Downloads - WeSay](#)

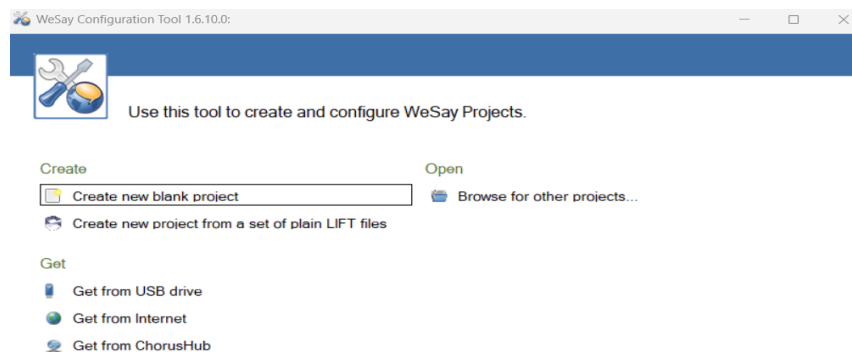
Downloads

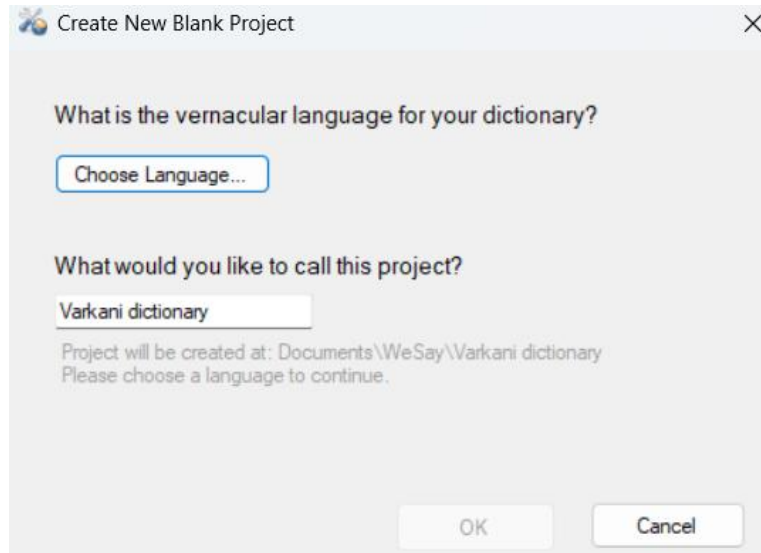


- Install and open the application

Step 2: Create a new project

- Click on create new blank project
- Enter:
 - Language name (e.g., *Varkani*)
 - Project name
- Choose storage location





Step 3: Find your language

If your language is not listed:

- Click on Ethnologue
- Navigate to the language database
- Use the search box to find your language

You can try:

- Different spellings
- Alternative names of the language

Lookup Language Code... ✕

Rayeji 🔍 [Can't find your language?](#)

Name	Code	Country	Other Names
Baruga	bjz	Papua New Guinea	Bareji, Mado, Tafota Baruga
Gaina	gcn	Papua New Guinea	Bareji, Baredji
Gbari	gby	Nigeria	Botai, Gayegi, Gbagyi Nkwa, Izem, Jezhu, Kong, Kwali, Kwange, Paiko, Wa
Kacchi	kfr	3 Countries	Jadeji, Cuchi, Cutch, Kachchhi, Kachchi, Kachi, Katch, Katchi, Kautchy, Kul
Kayeli	kzl	Indonesia	Leliali, Lumaete, Liliali, Lumaiti, Lumara, Mumaite, Caeli, Cajeli, Gaeli, Kajeli
Sindhi	sd	India, Pakistan, Sin...	Bhatia, Jadeji, Kayasthi, Lari, Lasi, Thareli, Thari, Viccholi, Visholi, Dukslinu,
Yeyi	yey	Botswana, Namibia	Shirwanga, Ciyei, Seyei, Seyeyi, Shiyeyi, Siyei, Wayeyi, Yeei, Yei, Mayeyi

You can change how the language name will be displayed here: **Baruga**

About The ISO Language Registry

This list should include all the ISO-639 languages, including all the alternative names known to ethnologue.com.

If necessary, use the "Unlisted Language" option, which will be selected for you now.

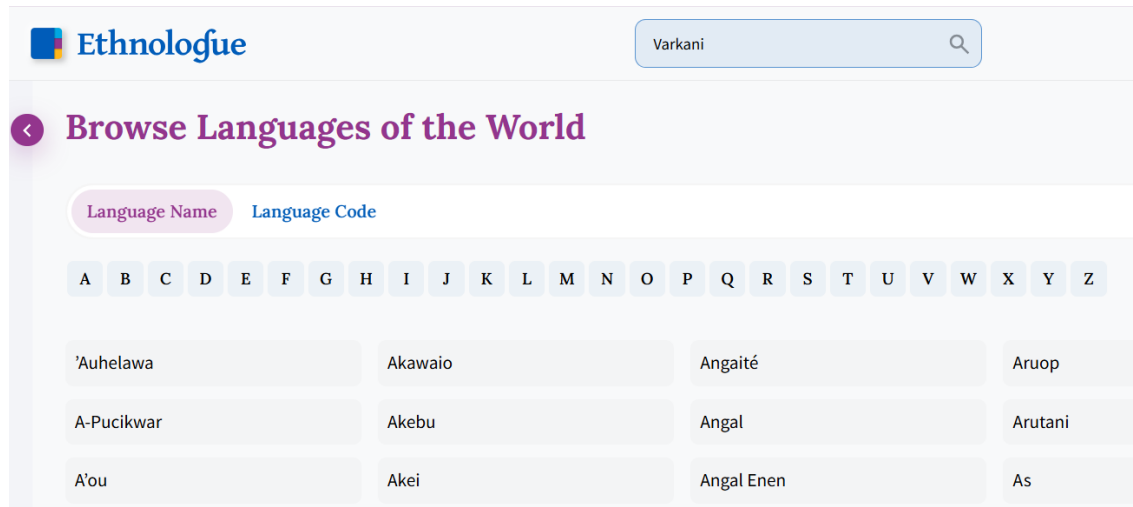
[Ethnologue.com](#)

[About Language 639-3 Codes & How To Apply For New Ones](#)

The following screenshot is from the Ethnologue website.



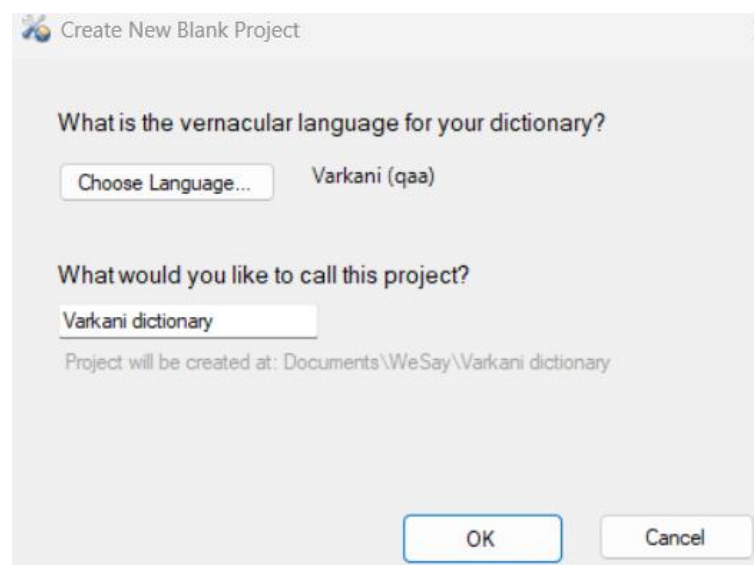
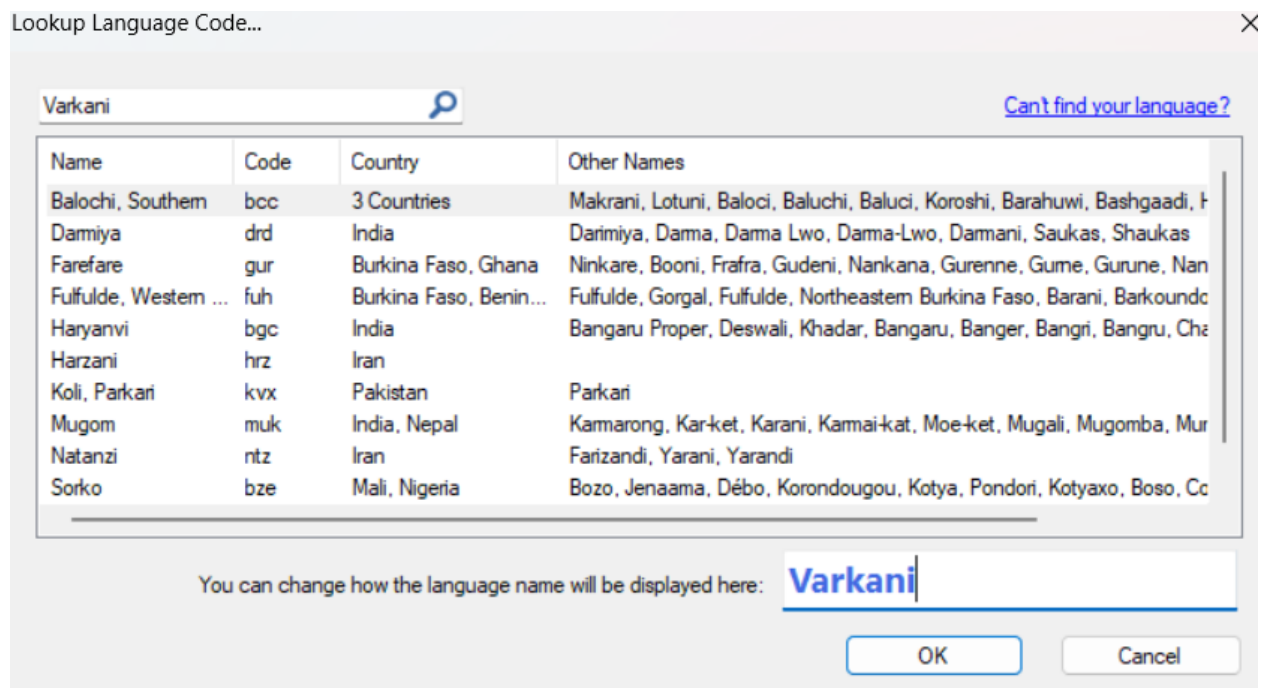
In the language box, you can search for the name of the language. I tried different terms.



If you still cannot find it:

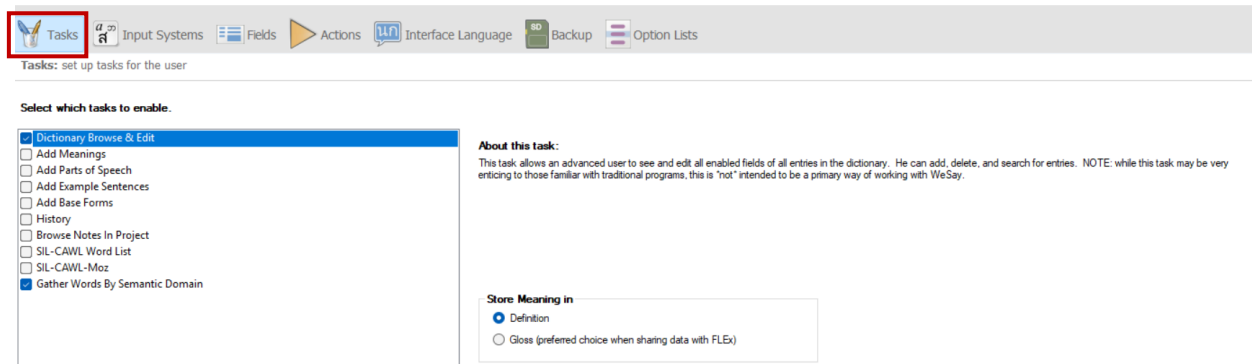
- Go back and manually enter the language name
- You may choose a specific variety name (e.g., a village dialect, as in your project)

👉 At this stage, your language will be assigned a language code, and your project name will be confirmed.



⚙️ Step 4: Choose Tasks and Settings

On the next page, you can select the types of tasks you want to perform.



Tasks: set up tasks for the user

Select which tasks to enable.

- ☒ Dictionary Browse & Edit
- ☐ Add Meanings
- ☐ Add Parts of Speech
- ☐ Add Example Sentences
- ☐ Add Base Forms
- ☐ History
- ☐ Browse Notes In Project
- ☐ SIL-CAWL Word List
- ☐ SIL-CAWL-Moz
- ☒ Gather Words By Semantic Domain

About this task:
This task allows an advanced user to see and edit all enabled fields of all entries in the dictionary. He can add, delete, and search for entries. NOTE: while this task may be very enticing to those familiar with traditional programs, this is "not" intended to be a primary way of working with WeSay.

Store Meaning in

☒ Definition

☐ Gloss (preferred choice when sharing data with FLEs)

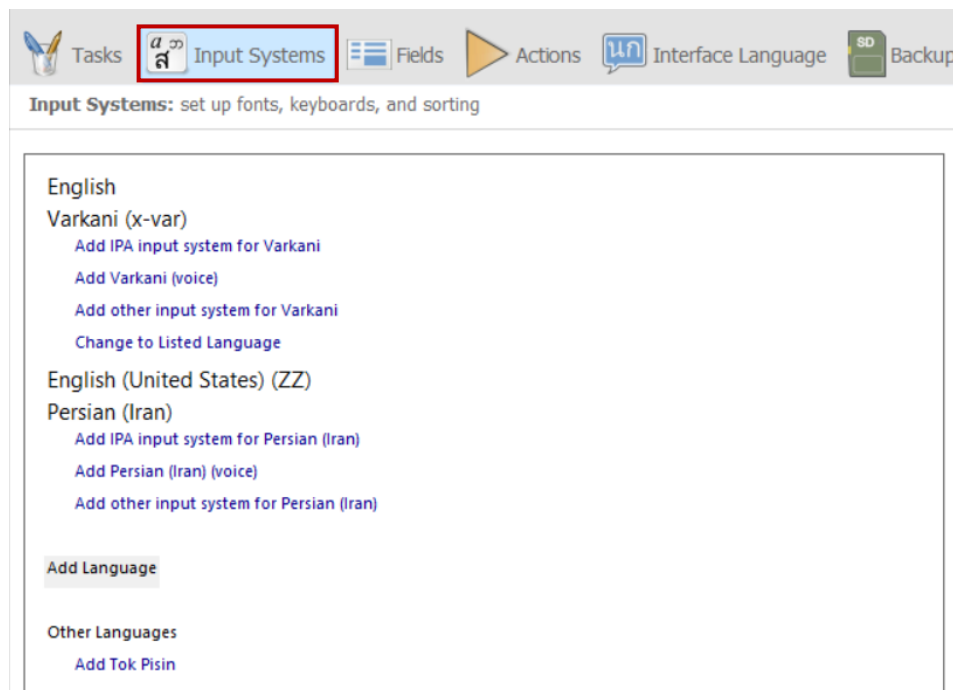
Input Systems

In the Input Systems tab, you can add additional languages.

Example:

- English
- Persian

This is useful for bilingual or trilingual dictionaries.



Input Systems: set up fonts, keyboards, and sorting

English

Varkani (x-var)

- Add IPA input system for Varkani
- Add Varkani (voice)
- Add other input system for Varkani
- Change to Listed Language

English (United States) (ZZ)

Persian (Iran)

- Add IPA input system for Persian (Iran)
- Add Persian (Iran) (voice)
- Add other input system for Persian (Iran)

Add Language

Other Languages

- Add Tok Pisin

Fields

In the Fields tab, select the types of information you want to include:

- Definitions
- Glosses
- Example sentences
- Images

Fields: set up the fields for the dictionary

Check each field you want WeSay to display.

Entry

- ☒ Word
- ☐ Citation Form
- ☐ Literal Meaning
- ☐ Base Form
- ☐ Cross Reference

Sense

- ☒ Definition (Meaning)
- ☐ Gloss
- ☒ Picture
- ☒ PartOfSpeech
- ☐ SILCAWL
- ☒ Sem Dom

Example

- ☒ Example Sentence
- ☐ Example Translation

Everywhere

- ☒ Note

Setup

Name for display: Word

Name in file: Entry/LexicalForm

Belongs to: Entry/Lexeme/Word

Data Type: Text in one or more input sys

Spelling: ☐ Enable spell checking

Visibility: ☐ Normally hidden if empty

Paragraph: ☐ Allow multiple paragraphs

Input Systems: ☒ Varkani (x-var), ☐ English, ☐ English (United States) (Z), ☐ Persian (Iran)

Description: The Lexeme Form of the entry.

Interface Language

This option allows you to:

- Change the interface language
- Adjust fonts and display settings

Interface Language: settings for the user interface

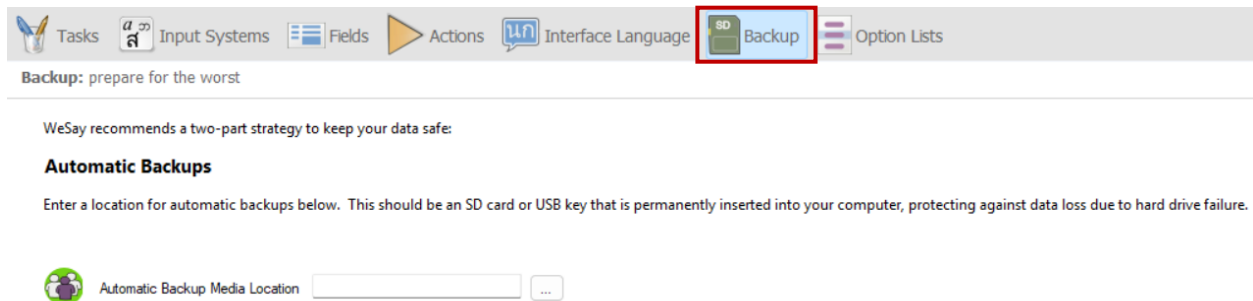
Interface Language: English (Default)

Interface Font: Segoe UI, 9 points

Backup

The Backup option ensures your data is saved securely.

👉 It is strongly recommended to enable regular backups.

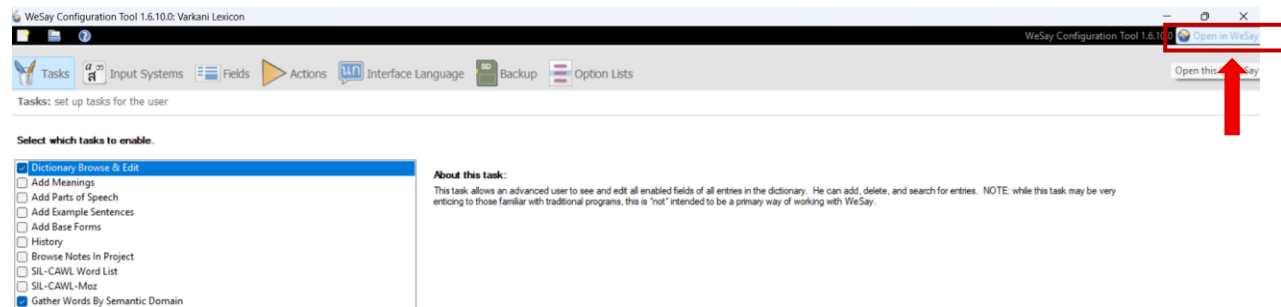


▶ Step 5: Start Working in WeSay

After setup, open your project in WeSay and begin adding entries.

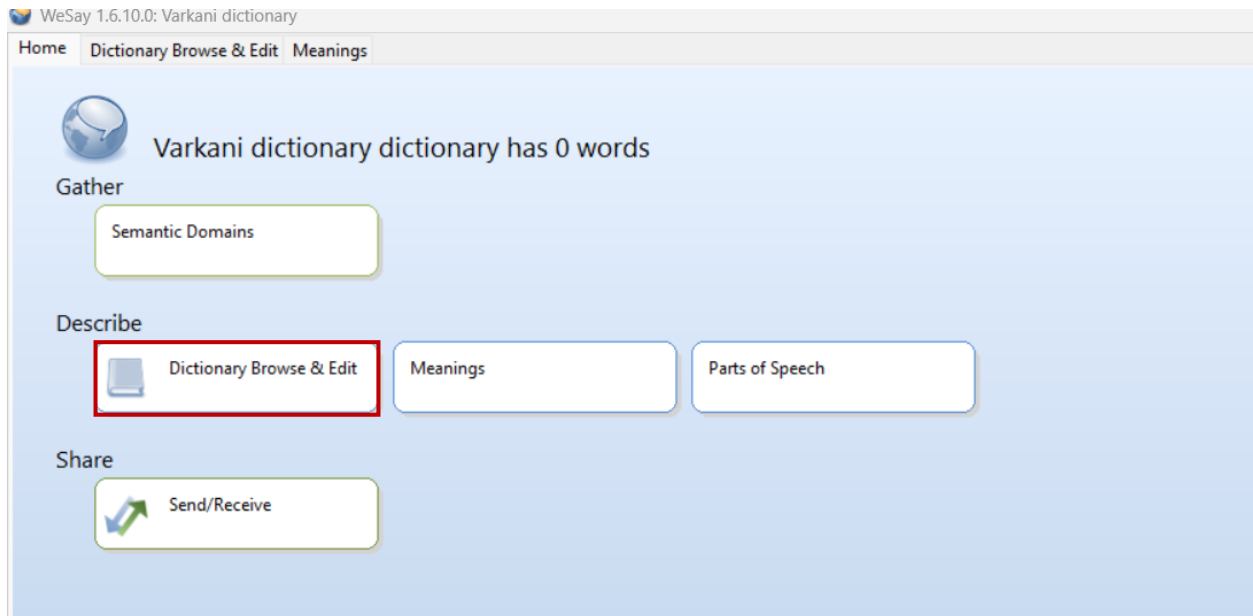
You can organize your work using:

- Semantic Domains
- Parts of Speech
- Dictionary Browse & Edit (simplest method)

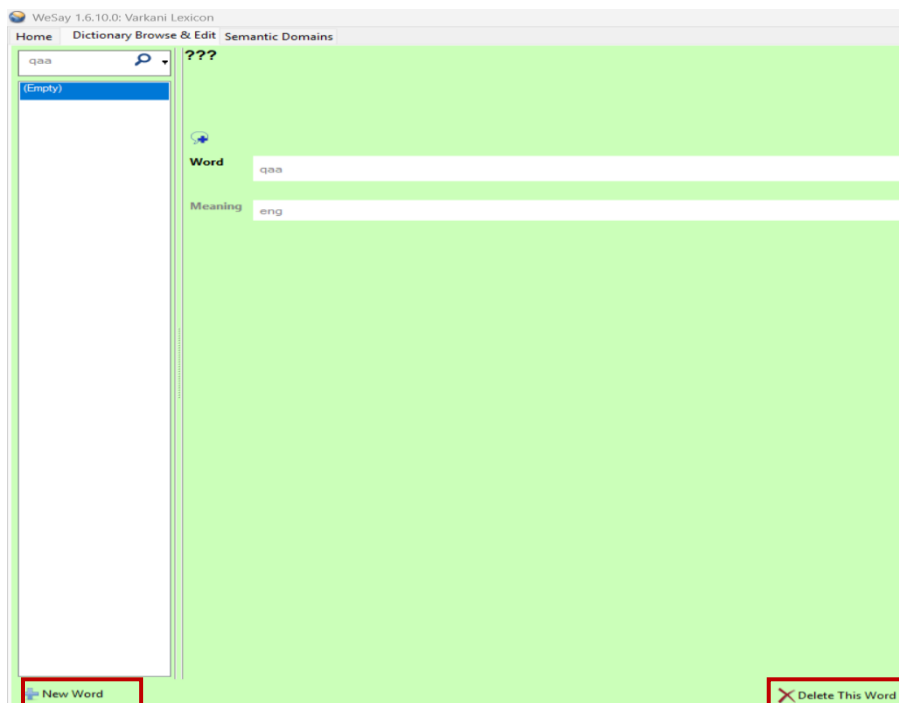


Step 6: Add and edit words

In the dictionary interface go to the Dictionary browse and edit.



- Add new words
- Delete or edit existing entries



When you add a word, more fields will appear:

- Part of speech
- Definition
- Example sentence
- Additional meanings (e.g., third language in a trilingual dictionary)

WeSay 1.6.10.0: Varkani Lexicon

Home Dictionary Browse & Edit Semantic Domains

qaa

(Empty)

xasru

xasru mother in law



Word

qaa xasru

Meaning 1

Gloss

eng mother in law

PartOfSpeech

Example

qaa

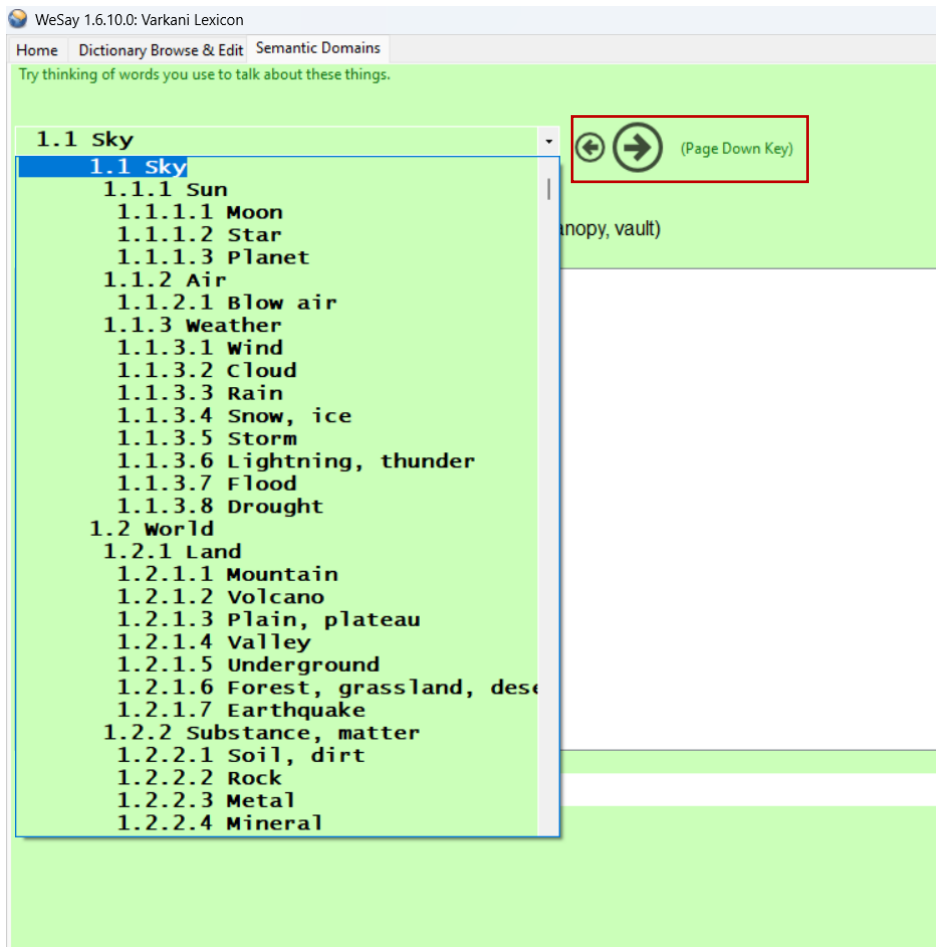
Meaning 2

eng

Step 7: Use Semantic Domains

One of the most powerful features of WeSay is Semantic Domains.

- These function like a guided questionnaire
- They help researchers and community members collect vocabulary systematically



You:

- Answer structured questions
- Move from one concept to another
- Gradually build a well-organized lexicon

WeSay 1.6.10.0: Varkani Lexicon

Home Dictionary Browse & Edit Semantic Domains

Try thinking of words you use to talk about these things.

1 Universe, creation  (Page Down Key)

(1) What words refer to everything we can see? (universe, creation, cosmos, heaven and earth, macrocosm, everything that exists)
Do not just translate these words; instead think of words in your own language.

Word qaa |

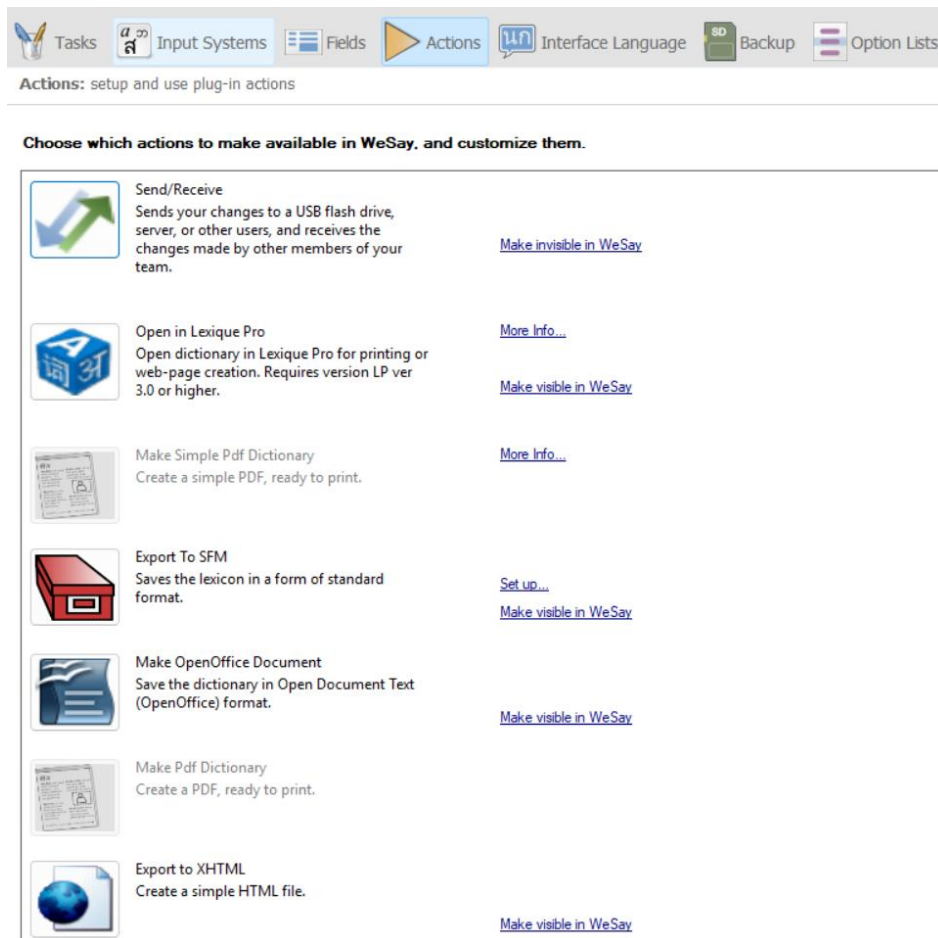
Step 8: Export options in Action tab

In **WeSay Configuration Tools**, you can view different export formats.

 WeSay works especially well with FieldWorks Language Explorer (FLEX).

Researchers often:

- Work in both WeSay and FLEX
- Use **Send/Receive** to synchronize data



Icon	Action Name	Description	Customization Link
	Send/Receive	Sends your changes to a USB flash drive, server, or other users, and receives the changes made by other members of your team.	Make invisible in WeSay
	Open in Lexique Pro	Open dictionary in Lexique Pro for printing or web-page creation. Requires version LP ver 3.0 or higher.	More Info... Make visible in WeSay
	Make Simple Pdf Dictionary	Create a simple PDF, ready to print.	More Info...
	Export To SFM	Saves the lexicon in a form of standard format.	Set up... Make visible in WeSay
	Make OpenOffice Document	Save the dictionary in Open Document Text (OpenOffice) format.	Make visible in WeSay
	Make Pdf Dictionary	Create a PDF, ready to print.	
	Export to XHTML	Create a simple HTML file.	Make visible in WeSay

Step 9: Importing LIFT into WeSay (FLEX Integration)

WeSay works with the **LIFT file format**, which is also used by FLEX. This allows you to transfer your dictionary between the two programs.

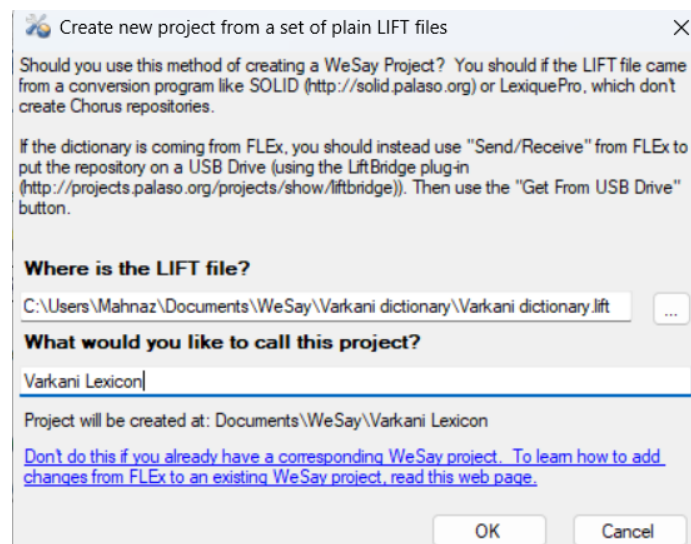
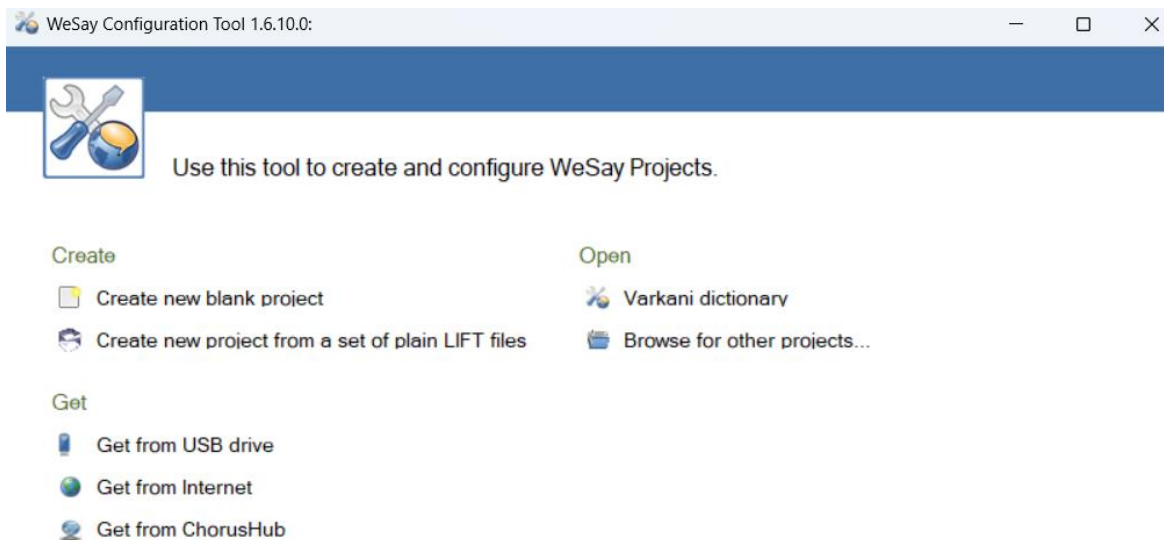
1 Steps:

1. In FLEX:
 - Go to **Export**
 - Save your dictionary as a **LIFT file**
2. In WeSay:
 - Select **Create Project From FLEX LIFT Export**
3. In the dialog window:
 - Click the ... (**ellipsis**) button
 - Locate your .lift file
 - Choose a project name
 - Click **OK**

Step 10: Alternative: Import via Configuration Tool

If the import window does not appear:

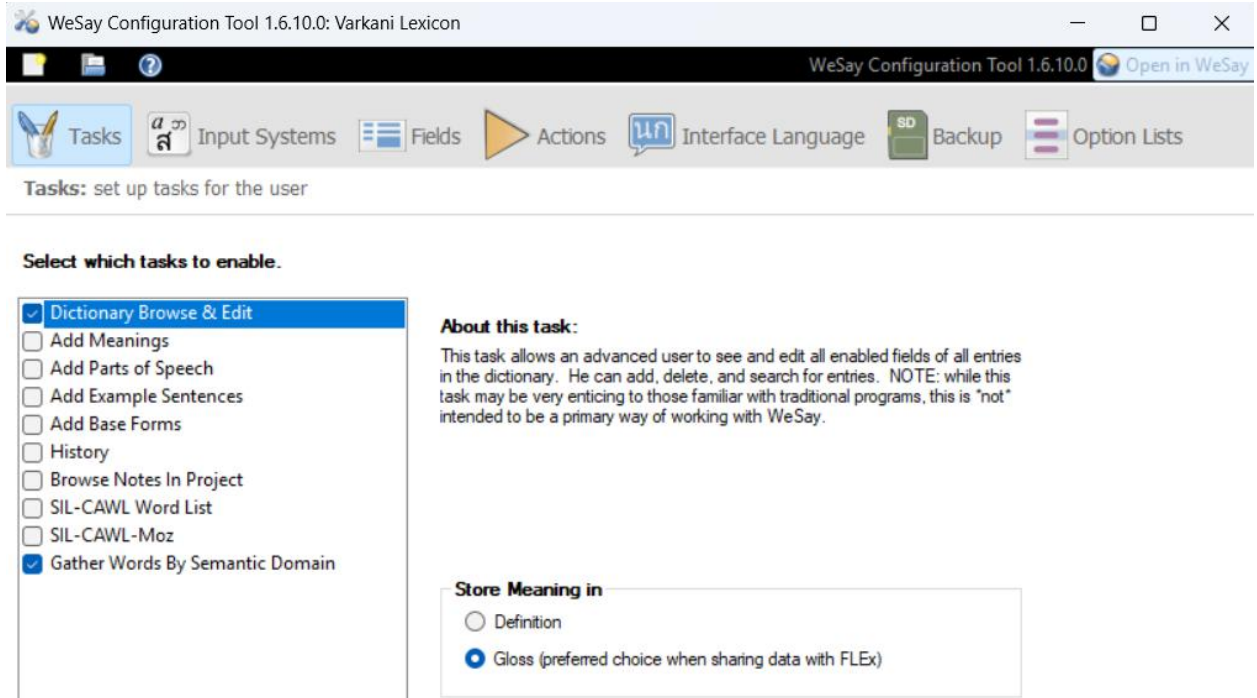
1. Open **WeSay Configuration Tool** (via Windows search)
2. Locate your LIFT file
3. Select it and name your project



Final Step

Once setup is complete:

- Open the project in WeSay
- Start adding or editing lexical entries



WeSay Configuration Tool 1.6.10.0: Varkani Lexicon

Tasks: set up tasks for the user

Select which tasks to enable.

☒ Dictionary Browse & Edit	About this task: This task allows an advanced user to see and edit all enabled fields of all entries in the dictionary. He can add, delete, and search for entries. NOTE: while this task may be very enticing to those familiar with traditional programs, this is "not" intended to be a primary way of working with WeSay.
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